

Opelika Grows

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To Alabama Power Foundation

Areas of Concentration: Increase access to affordable, accessible, and fresh food for more than 5252 low-income residents in Opelika yearly

Title of Project:

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Abstract

Opelika Grows (O Grows) is a nonprofit organization established in 2014 that aims to provide affordable, accessible, and fresh food for Opelika, Lee County, and beyond. In the past decade, it has been helping to secure thousands of residents and their families with lower prices and free food with just less than four staff members, a small outdoor garden, and a greenhouse framework. This year, we are planning to build a new greenhouse to expand our capacity for food supply and better provide and explore more educational programming for communities and society. This plan also aligns well with the current accessible and fresh food crisis locally.

Food security is the foundation for every person's quality of life and long-term health. However, it is a big concern for many cities nationwide, just as in Lee County. The increase in unemployment among residents and the reduction in support from the public due to the social environment exacerbate the insecurity of food supplies. This will presumably cause stress on their mental and physical health. And we aim to help by having a greenhouse and providing year-round fresh food. After years of service, we are limited by the seasonal limitation to help more individuals and families.

O Grows intends to apply for funding in the total of \$34,743.98 from Alabama Power Foundation, which includes a new greenhouse modular structure from a selected vendor, installation fee, and some planting tools for the farm. The founder, Dr. Forbes, who has more than 20 years of teaching experience and leadership in different programs, will lead three other team members to implement and accomplish this project. We are confident that the new greenhouse, along with other needed facility updates, will allow us to largely increase production to secure more people with affordable, accessible, and fresh food.

Introduction

At Opelika Grows (O Grows), our community greenhouse and garden have long served as a space for food production, environmental education and community engagement. Our non-profit organization is a community food security initiative with the mission to 'cultivate local food, knowledge sharing and relationships' in Opelika, headquartered at the Southside Centre for the Arts. O Grows community garden was established in 2014 to promote local and agricultural awareness while producing vegetable and plant supplies; the greenhouse has supported seasonal growing initiatives, youth education programs, and volunteer-driven food distribution efforts. As a participant of Alabama Cooperative Extension's Grow More Give More campaign, half of the outdoor garden (6,000 sq ft) is

planted/harvested by O Grows staff with the assistance and support of the Lee County Master Gardeners and Bonnie Plants, as well as other volunteers from Opelika.

Our non-profit organization has held annual strawberry and other festivals and collaborates with and supports local farmers to provide the community with access to local, fresh produce. O Grows Farmers Market is the only state-certified, direct-to-consumer farmers market in Opelika, and is the only venue with vendors who accept the Alabama Senior Farmers Market Nutrition program cards. On average, O Grows has donated over 1,600 pounds of produce in support of the local hunger relief to the Community Market of the East Alabama Food Bank. In 2024, O Grows established relationships with the Opelika Senior Centre and Opelika Housing Authority for direct distribution to residents, and in 2025, installed adaptive raised beds for the exclusive use by clients of the Opelika Senior Centre. The other 6,000 sq ft of the garden is planted/harvested annually by 25 (avg) resident individuals/ families for personal consumption. Serving local areas with food and beyond for more than a decade, O Grows is growing and hoping to improve its work environment to better support communities in 2026.

The primary objective of this proposal is to secure funding for structural repairs and replacement, system modernizations, and efficiency upgrades that will further contribute to full functionality and increase the greenhouse's year-round yield production capacity. Over the years, O Grows has increasingly addressed the community food security needs of Opelika and its environment. However, deteriorating and outdated systems have now limited our capacity to meet the growing demands. With these improvements, the greenhouse is projected to expand youth and community education programming and strengthen partnerships focused on sustainability and local development while expanding access to fresh produce and hands-on learning to the families and community we serve.

Current Situation

In recent years, downtown Opelika, Alabama, has experienced a notable revival following decades of stagnation. This progress has been driven by building renovations, new restaurants and retail development, and an increase in community events and festivals. Despite this economic growth, food insecurity remains a serious issue. According to DataUSA, the poverty rate is 16% among the population of 32,820 in 2024, and the situation is exacerbated by rising unemployment and an increasingly unstable political and social environment.

These challenges are especially severe in the Carver and Jeter neighborhoods, located south of downtown. Many low-income residents in these areas experience limited food access, with very low levels of food self-reliance. Residents

are largely disconnected from local food production and distribution systems, relying heavily on retail options. With only one grocery store serving these communities, convenience stores, many of which accept federal assistance benefits, are often the primary food source.

In 2014, access to local food gained attention through the Carver-Jeter Task Force, a 20-week strategic planning effort focused on land use, public services, and economic development. The goal of this planning effort was to engage with residents, community organizations, and city agencies. Significant input came from two large public meetings that included interactive activities. About 250 people attended these sessions, with 45% identifying as recipients of public food assistance programs such as SNAP, WIC, or local food pantries. These findings highlighted the community's need for improved food access and informed future planning efforts.

Many low-income residents rely on food assistance from food retailers, food pantries, and soup kitchens that are not easily accessible. Among these resources, the Community Market of the Food Bank of East Alabama provides the most stable and consistent support. Recent population growth, combined with declining employment since 2024 (DataUSA), has increased demand for fresh, affordable food. At present, the impact of the community garden on low-income residents in the area has been minimal due to insufficient infrastructure. To address this gap and expand food insecurity and accessibility, O Grows proposes building a greenhouse at the farm to increase production capacity and provide a more stable, year-round supply of fresh produce for the community.

In response to the need for increase access to local foods and fresh produce, current project partners built on an existing collaboration between the community and Auburn University through O Grows, using available human and financial resources to establish a community garden in 2014 and launch a farmers' market at the Southside Center (SC) in 2016. Located at the intersection of the Carver and Jeter communities, the SC is the center of the community for food security efforts led by Envision Opelika, connecting farmers, consumers, and residents.

The community garden (O Grows') engages more than 30 resident gardeners, including 10 - 12 low-income participants, along with hundreds of visitors and students involved in food production and food security initiatives led by farmers, local businesses, and extension professionals. Thousands of pounds of produce have been donated to the Food Bank of East Alabama. The farmers market supports commerce among over 12 small and mid-sized farmers and value-added producers, serving more than 300 residents, while several farmers regularly contribute to the gleaning and donation program.

Funding for a greenhouse is imperative to sustain and expand the progress already made in improving food access within these communities. While existing efforts have increased the availability of fresh produce, we remain limited by seasonal growing conditions and inconsistent supply. A new greenhouse will enable year-round production, stabilize food availability, and strengthen local food systems. It will also deepen community engagement, support local growers, and increase donations to food assistance programs. This investment is essential to building long-term food security, resilience, and self-reliance for underserved residents and helps reduce the gap in access to affordable and nutritious food.

Project Plan

Goals and Objectives

The primary goal of this project is to acquire and install a greenhouse with additional needed equipment that will help further strengthen the productivity, sustainability, and accessibility of the local community garden within the Opelika area. The greenhouse will serve as a controlled growing environment that supports cultivation throughout the year and reduces dependency on seasonal limitations.

The objectives of this project are defined as follows:

- To extend the growing season by enabling planting and harvesting during the colder and adverse weather seasons. To increase the variety of crops that can be cultivated, including those requiring stable temperatures and humidity conditions.
- To improve the overall crop yield by reducing losses due to pests, frost, and inconsistent environmental conditions.
- To establish a reliable space for seed starting/ seedling, and plant propagation.
- To support hands-on learning related to greenhouse use and sustainable gardening.
- To strengthen participation by providing a shared, functional resource for local community members.
- These objectives collectively support improved food production, operational consistency, and engagement with the community and the garden.

Methodology

Planning and Design

Considerations for the project included determining the appropriate specifications for a modular greenhouse and integrating the pre-selected modular greenhouse into integrating a pre-selected modular greenhouse effectively and efficiently. Measurements of the designated area were taken to confirm that the greenhouse fits within the available space without interfering with existing plots, walkways or other garden infrastructure.

Environmental considerations are critical to ensure the greenhouse functions and operates properly. The site would be further evaluated for drainage to prevent water accumulation and maintain a stable foundation. Minor ground leveling will be conducted as necessary, and any other modifications required to accommodate the modular kit will be completed prior to construction.

All preparation steps will ensure that the site is ready for the installation. This includes confirming that the ground is stable, levelling any areas, and making any adjustments required by the greenhouse kit specifications. By completing these planning steps, the project ensures that the greenhouse will be installed smoothly, function efficiently and meet O Grows' community garden long term cultivation and educational goals.

Procurement and Delivery Process

The modular structure (Economy Starter Greenhouse Package: 30 ft. x 48 ft. x 4 ft. sidewalls) has already been identified and selected for this project based on its suitability for the community garden's space, functionality, and budget. The procurement process will therefore focus on acquisition, delivery coordination and verification rather than selection.

The first step was to confirm that the selected greenhouse kit aligned with the approved project budget and included all the structural components. This ensures that no additional major purchases were required beyond the funding amount requested. Delivery coordination will be managed to align with the project timeline, ensuring that all materials arrive prior to the construction phase. This will include confirming estimated delivery dates and preparing the site to receive and store materials securely until assembly begins.

Upon delivery, all components will be inventoried and inspected. Each item will be checked against the order list to verify completeness and condition. Any missing or damaged parts will be documented and addressed with the vendor to avoid any delays in construction.

Construction

The greenhouse will be assembled according to the manufacturer's specifications. The modular design will allow for efficient assembly, with clearly defined components and steps. Volunteer teams would work under supervision to ensure proper installation, alignment and structural stability.

Interior Setup

After construction of the modular structure, the interior layout of the greenhouse would be organized to optimize growing space and workflow. Shelving, plant benches, walkways, and basic irrigation systems to support consistent watering will be installed. Ventilation features included in the kit will be configured to maintain air flow and temperature control.

This process ensures that the modular greenhouse is acquired efficiently, remains within budget, and is ready for assembly without interruption to the project schedule.

Training and Orientation

Volunteers and community members will be trained on greenhouse use and maintenance. Instructions will focus on plant care, watering instructions, environmental monitoring, and routine upkeep. This ensures consistent and effective use of the greenhouse.

Projected Timeline

The project will be completed over a 14-week (about 3 months) period to account for the 6-week delivery time of the modular greenhouse kit.

Weeks 1 – 2: Planning and Site preparation

Assess environmental conditions, prepare the ground, and complete any levelling or minor modifications required for installation.

Week 3: Procurement/ Ordering

Place the order for the modular greenhouse kit with the vendor. Confirm payment, delivery schedule, and order details.

Weeks 4 – 9: Delivery Period

While awaiting delivery, complete any remaining site preparations, organize tools and materials, and plan interior layout. Maintain communication with the vendor to track shipment process.

Weeks 10 – 11: Construction

Assemble the modular greenhouse upon delivery. Volunteer team, supervised by the construction lead, will complete installation following the manufacturer's guidelines.

Week 12: Interior Setup

Install shelving, basic irrigation systems, and organize the interior for ideal plant growth and workflow.

Week 13: Training

Conduct volunteer training and community members' orientation on greenhouse use, maintenance, and plant care practices.

Week 14: Project Completion and Evaluation Preparation

Confirm readiness for use, verify functionality, and prepare evaluation procedures to track success metrics such as productivity, usage, and community engagement.

This timeline will help identify and keep track of all project phases, aligning with the delivery schedule, while providing time for preparation, assembly, and training before full operation.

Roles and Responsibilities

Since its founding in 2012 by Dr. Forbes Sean, O Grows has developed into a strong team with four staff members and approximately 20 dedicated volunteers. Each of the four team members has their personal strength and specific responsibilities, but they work collaboratively as one to develop O Grows. They devote their time, passion, and care to building the garden and supporting the community.

Dr. Forbes is the director of the O Grows Community-University Partnership, and he is also a professor of Educational Psychology. He obtained a Ph.D. degree from the University of Florida in 1999 and has been teaching in the Department of Educational Foundations, Leadership & Technology, College of Education, Auburn University for about 20 years. Due to his outstanding contribution in education and leadership, Dr. Forbes was nominated for the Royrickers *Cook Engagement Award in 2024* by colleagues from his department. The

other three team members are Antonio Martinez, Jonney Whyte, and James Stephens. They are all hired as full-time employees with different roles and responsibilities listed below:

Team members	Roles	Responsibilities
Dr. Forbes Sean	Director	Is responsible for the management of O Grows operation and budget management
Antonio Martinez	Community and Market Manager	Is responsible for communicating, coordinating, creating, and cultivating relationships between O Grows and our community, including events put on by O Grows. Creates and distributes content and related materials through social media channels and print media. Maintains up to date documents, spreadsheets, planning, and event related materials
Jonney Whyte	Production Manager	Is responsible for the management of all production of vegetable and ornamental plant material, maintaining the health and beautification of the community garden and green spaces, as well as the greenhouse. This position is also responsible for coordination of agricultural-education needs.
James Stephens	Facilities Manager	Is responsible for the management of the physical O Grows education and community spaces. These spaces include the outdoor garden areas, greenhouse, commons, workshop, and goat infrastructure & enclosure.

O Grows is making a contribution to the local food security and agricultural education with these warm-hearted and responsible individuals. As we mentioned, it is also supported by other organizations and partners locally and nationwide in return. Thus, O Grows is aspiring to expand its capacity and support communities and society with a new Greenhouse. The budget cost for it will be illustrated in the next section.

Budget Cost

As mentioned, the funding request is intended to support the construction of a greenhouse. O Grows planned to purchase a modular structure, “Economy Starter Greenhouse Package,” from [Greenhouse MegaStore](#) at a total cost of \$24,758.00, which includes free shipping. The vendor’s quoted installation fee is from \$15,000 to \$ 30,000 among three options. So, to reduce the overall cost, we researched alternative options and decided to hire three contractors from the local community to complete the installation.

The total cost for the installation, including three laborers and scaffolding rental, is \$ 13,000. With an in-kind donation valued at \$4,000, the requested cash expenditure for installation is reduced to \$9,000.

To better align with our mission and development, O Grows will also continue to support agricultural education programs with the communities, including teenagers and college interns. We are requesting additional funding of \$796.00 and \$189.98 to purchase four 8-bucket hydroponic systems and two 54-hole horizontal pipe systems, respectively. Combined with the other 2 passive hydroponic systems we already own, the Dutch buckets and horizontal pipe systems will enable O Grows to nearly triple our year-round production. In addition, they will help expand more STEM-related programming for students at OLC and allow us to offer hydroponics-focused educational opportunities for the broader community.

Please see the detailed Project Cost below:

Budget Item	Cost of Item(s) to Purchase	Amount Requested from Alabama Power Foundation
Greenhouse Package	\$24,758.00	\$24,758.00
Labor for Installation	\$ 13,000, including 4000 in-kind donations	\$9,000
Transportation	For free	0.00
4 kits of the 8-bucket systems (VIVOSUN DWC Hydroponics Grow System with Top Drip Kit)	\$199 x 4 = \$796	\$796
2 of the 54 hold horizontal pipe systems (INTBUYING Hydroponics Growing System)	\$94.99 x 2 = \$189.98	\$189.98
Site Clearance	Included in staff salary	0.00
Maintenance	Included in staff salary	0.00

In total	\$38743	\$34,743.98
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Since most of the O Grows staff members are experienced gardeners and some of them are specialized in construction, assembly of the greenhouse will be with their own internal labor. Additionally, to reduce the budget, the team plans to invite a local contractor who has extensive experience in greenhouse construction.

Budget Justification

A greenhouse with necessary supplies is a practical investment that will directly improve and meet the demand for food access and community well-being in an underserved area with limited availability of fresh produce. Currently, residents in the Carver-Jeter area rely heavily on the local community garden. The addition of the greenhouse will extend the growing season, protect crops from harsh and extreme weather, and allow for increased year-round production of fruits and vegetables to meet the community's needs and demand. It also increases the quality and reliability of fresh produce available to the community. Additional greenhouse supplies, such as hydroponic gardening horizontal grow systems, and hydroponic top drip grow systems will be essential in ensuring efficient operation and maximizing yield.

Beyond food production, the greenhouse will serve as a community resource for education and engagement. It can support workshops on gardening, nutrition and sustainability, and fosters community collaboration, strengthening local resilience and environmental stewardship.

Conclusion

The request for funding from the Alabama Power Foundation Grant Program seeks to strengthen Opelika Grows' (O Grows) in increasing food production and contributing to improve the residents' accessibility to affordable fresh produce, keeping with mission of the Alabama Foundation grant in "improving the life for fellow Alabamians."

Being able to acquire this infrastructure and the necessary growing supplies will allow O Grows to expand its role in the local food system. The addition of hydroponic systems will support consistent, year-round growth, creating a dependable source of fresh fruits and vegetables for the community, especially to low-income families.

This grant seeks proposal for this greenhouse project, through planning and designing, delivery and installation, budgeting and cost, etc., for the greenhouse ensures that every area of the implementation of a new greenhouse is done successfully.

References